

# FROM BALL BOY TO BEACON

From idolising Sardar to injecting for Harmanpreet, India's vice-captain Hardik Singh is chasing more than just medals.

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**A**s vice-captain and one of the mainstays of the Indian men's hockey team over the last two Olympic cycles, Hardik Singh might appear most at ease on hockey fields across the world. But it's in one corner of Jalandhar where he truly feels at home.

"I only get to spend a few months every year here. But if there's one place that I long to visit, it's right here," he said when he met *Sportstar* just before the European leg of the Pro League.

With Olympic rings mounted in metal on its façade, it's hard to miss the 26-year-old's newly constructed two-storey home just outside the village of Khusropur. But this wasn't always the case.

"I've grown up in this exact place. This is my childhood home, but after the 2020 Olympics, I was thinking of renovating a couple of rooms. But after I got a bit of money, I decided to demolish and rebuild the same thing. A lot of people suggested that I build

a home in Chandigarh, but I never had any other thought than to make my home right here. I don't think I get the same kind of peace anywhere else," he says.

Hardik is a self-confessed hockey nerd. When he plays fetch on the lawn with his German Shepherd, *Marshal*, it's often with a hockey ball that he strikes using a hockey stick. Inside his home, behind glass, are framed kits of Harmanpreet Singh and Manpreet Singh — two of India's top players — with plans to add more.

His two Olympic bronze medals from the Tokyo and Paris Games aren't kept under lock and key, though.

"When I'm around, people always want to see them. So I bring them out and let people hold them. The medal from Paris has got a little dirty, but I don't mind. The point of these medals is for people to see them," he says.

While two Olympic bronze medals might seem like a major achievement across much of India, Hardik insists that's not quite the case in his part of Punjab. His house is a short walk from Khusropur, the ancestral village of his paternal family.

"Khusropur has had a huge part to play in the history of hockey in India. There are so many players from here who have played for India. If you include mine, people from my village have won a total of seven Olympic medals," he says.

## Family tradition

Hardik's family also has a rich history with the sport. His grandfather coached the Navy team, where his uncle Jugraj and aunt Rajbir both represented India. His father, too, made it to the national camp before giving up his career to support the family.

Perhaps the most celebrated of his relatives is his father's uncle, Gurmail Singh, who won gold at the 1980 Moscow Olympics.

"Even now, when we sit together, my uncle will keep saying how his generation of players were the greatest ever. And my dad says no: hockey has changed so much. There are things like zonal structure which weren't always there. But at the end of the day, my *chacha* has the Olympic gold! I can't show off just yet. I have a bronze, but a gold is something different. I'd grown up hearing stories of my *chacha's*